

UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper 1 Simulation

DETAILED SOLUTIONS / ANSWER KEY | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

SECTION A - Socio-Political Philosophy

Q1 (COMPULSORY)

(a) Discuss Kautilya's concept of sovereignty in the light of 'Danda-neety'. [10 marks]

Model answer (182 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. For Kautilya, sovereignty is measured by the ruler's capacity to calibrate force, not by his freedom to use it; dandaniti is therefore a doctrine of proportion rather than of severity. Where coercion sits. Coercive force (danda) is one of the seven constituents of the state (saptanga), alongside the ruler (svami), ministers (amatya), territory with its people (janapada), fortified defence (durga), treasury (kosa) and ally (mitra). Placing it among the constituents makes the capacity to punish a permanent structural feature of rule rather than an emergency power. The calibration argument. Without danda, society falls into disorder; with excessive danda, the ruler breeds resentment and instability. The art of sovereignty therefore lies in ordered, proportionate enforcement - danda is the force and niti the policy that governs its use. What this shows about sovereignty. The ruler is head of an organism rather than an unlimited master: authority is real, but its legitimacy and durability are judged by order and by security and welfare (yogaksema). Fear without welfare is self-defeating; welfare without order is impossible. Verdict. Kautilyan sovereignty is strong precisely because it is duty-bound.

(b) "Toleration is not equality." Comment. [10 marks]

Model answer (181 words; practice model, not official): Claim. The statement is correct, and it identifies the single most useful control in this clause. The distinction. Toleration is permission to dissent: one party restrains coercion against what it disapproves of. Equality is a claim about standing: no party holds the position from which permission could be granted. Why the difference is structural, not one of degree. Toleration presupposes an asymmetry - a permitter and a permitted. That asymmetry is a civic rank, and softening its exercise does not remove it. The decisive evidence is institutional: a state with an established religion can be highly tolerant of others while its dissenters remain unequal citizens. Toleration therefore survives precisely the arrangement that equality abolishes. The same structure at the level of culture. The diversity ladder repeats the point: tolerance restrains coercion but preserves a hierarchy of permission, and a mature order moves through accommodation and recognition to equal citizenship and reciprocal recognition. What toleration nonetheless supplies. It is a necessary condition. Without restraint on coercion, plural communities cannot share a polity at all, and recognition has nothing to build on. Qualification. Verdict.

(c) "Untouchability is a symptom of caste, not a synonym for it." Examine the significance of this distinction. [10 marks]

Model answer (194 words; practice model, not official): Position. The distinction is not terminological housekeeping; it decides what a remedy must reach. The four terms. The textual fourfold order is a normative classification and is not identical with the lived order; the lived birth-group is a locally organised, generally endogamous group, of which there are thousands with wide regional variation; the caste system is the institutional order joining birth, marriage closure, ranked status, allocated occupation and restricted association; and untouchability names practices imposing extreme exclusion and stigma on designated groups. Why untouchability is a symptom. The ranking principle - that birth fixes worth - operates throughout the order. Untouchability is its most extreme expression, so a rule abolishing the practice can succeed while birth continues to allocate marriage, occupation and standing everywhere else. The doctrinal consequence. This is why Ambedkar holds that untouchability cannot be eliminated without annihilating caste, and why reform limited to the practice is rejected as insufficient. The evaluative consequence. It also fixes the terms of the Gandhi-Ambedkar dispute: a position can condemn untouchability without opposing an idealised duty-order that still allocates by birth. Verdict. Merging the terms makes both positions unstable and converts a structural argument into a moral one.

(d) Comment on Plato's critique of Democracy. [10 marks]

Model answer (187 words; practice model, not official): The exact target. Plato attacks rule driven by unrestrained appetite and unexamined opinion, not participation as such. Stating the target precisely is what prevents the answer from becoming a summary of prejudices. The argument, in three moves. First, rule is a craft requiring knowledge: the ship-of-state analogy denies that navigation may be entrusted to the unskilled merely because they are numerous. Second, democracy mistakes liberty for qualification, so an equal right to rule is treated as an equal capacity to rule, levelling knowledge and ignorance. Third, unregulated liberty makes restraint appear oppressive, and out of that licence emerges the demagogue who flatters the many, attacks elites and seizes absolute power - so democracy turns into tyranny. The correction that must be made. This is not a defence of hereditary monarchy. Plato's rulers are selected by training and knowledge, which is why the modern reply targets unaccountable expertise rather than inheritance. The reply. Expertise informs policy while equal citizens retain authority over common purposes; constitutional liberty is ordered by rights and accountability; plural media, opposition and review can expose manipulation; and legitimate plurality is preferable to enforced unity. Verdict.

(e) Distinguish between economic growth, human development and social progress. Why does the distinction matter? [10 marks]

Model answer (195 words; practice model, not official): The three concepts. Economic growth is increase in aggregate or per-capita output; its question is whether more is being produced. Human development, in the framework associated with Mahbub ul Haq and the UNDP, is expansion of longevity, knowledge and a decent material standard; its question is whether basic human options are widening. Social progress is justified improvement in social relations and institutions, assessed through freedom, equality, justice, dignity, participation, sustainability and solidarity; its question is whether society has become defensibly better. Three informational spaces. The three are measured in different spaces, which is why none entails the next. Output cannot see distribution, unpaid work or externalities; a national human-development composite cannot see within-group inequality or political freedom; and social progress cannot be settled by any aggregate at all, since the weights between its criteria are the normative question. Why it matters - three consequences. It supplies the discriminating test: income rising alongside intensified unfreedom, humiliation or ecological destruction is growth without progress. It makes the modal questions answerable, since necessity and sufficiency can only be assessed between distinct conditions. It locates the missing term in most development failures - not more output but standing and agency. Verdict.

Q2

(a) "The concept of supreme legal authority survives every criticism examined; the image of a determinate personal sovereign does not." Critically examine this verdict with reference to Bodin, Austin, Laski and Kautilya. [20 marks]

Model answer (354 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The verdict is sound but requires two amendments: the surviving concept is final procedure rather than final will, and Kautilya shows that a duty-bound personal head can survive where an illimitable one cannot. What the image asserts. Bodin's sovereign is the absolute and perpetual power of a commonwealth; Austin's is a determinate human superior, habitually obeyed by the bulk and obeying no one, whose authority is absolute, indivisible, illimitable and inalienable. The internal criticisms. Austin cannot explain succession, persistence or power-conferring rules. Kelsen (General Theory of Law and State, English edition 1945) replaces the commander with a hierarchy of norms terminating in a presupposed basic norm; Hart (The Concept of Law, 1961) replaces him with a union of primary and secondary rules resting on a rule of recognition accepted from the internal point of view. Both remain positivists: the image dissolves, the concept of ultimate validity does not. The external criticisms. Federalism distributes competence; international law binds without a world sovereign; custom precedes command; democracy makes authority derivative and answerable. Laski adds that absolutism is philosophically false, politically dangerous and sociologically unrealistic. Each attacks the personal image; none shows that a legal order can dispense with an ultimate criterion of validity. What Bodin retains. Bodin survives better than Austin because his sovereign is already limited by divine law, natural law and the fundamental laws of the realm, and because perpetuity locates authority in an office. His weakness is enforcement, not conception. What Kautilya adds. The seven-limbed state makes sovereignty systemic; calibrated coercion makes force proportionate; security and welfare make legitimacy conditional on outcomes. A head bound by dharma, counsel, treasury and welfare is not the illimitable superior the criticisms destroy, which is why Kautilya is the least damaged of the four. The amendments. First, what survives is best described as a final procedure for closure rather than a final will, since Hart's rule of recognition and a constitutional amending procedure both perform closure without personal supremacy. Second, the three dissolutions must not be merged: a norm-hierarchy, an official practice and a plurality of associations are rivals, not allies. Verdict. The quoted verdict holds.

(b) 'There is no permanent friend or permanent enemy.' Discuss this statement in the light of Kautilya's view on Sovereignty. [15 marks]

Model answer (279 words; practice model, not official): Provenance first. The printed line is the examiner's framing. What can be shown is that the verified doctrines make alliances conditional and policy responsive. Thesis. On Kautilya's model, friendship and enmity are positional rather than personal, so the conditionality the line asserts follows from the structure of interstate relations and needs no quotation to establish it. The circle of states. The mandala framework locates friends and enemies relationally within a competitive and unstable states-system, in which position rather than sentiment fixes alignment. The six-fold policy. Sadgunya supplies the gears: sandhi (peace or treaty), vighraha (hostility or war), yana (marching or expedition), asana (remaining poised), samsraya (seeking shelter or alliance) and dvaidhibhava (dual policy). Policy therefore changes with circumstance, relative power and interest - a thesis of strategic flexibility, not a verbatim maxim. Why permanence is unavailable. If alignment is defined by relative position, then a state that gains or loses power changes position, and a change of position changes which measure is prudent. Conditionality falls out of the model rather than being asserted about it. The internal counterweight. External flexibility is not amorality. Sovereignty is also bound internally by the seven limbs (saptanga), by calibrated coercion (dandaniti) and by the duty to security and welfare (yogaksema). Kautilya is realistic but not normless. Objection and reply. Objection: such realism is cynical. Reply: strategic flexibility operates alongside the ruler's internal duty toward order and welfare, and misrule weakens sovereignty itself. Verdict. The statement is a fair interpretation of Kautilya's external sovereignty and a poor summary of his theory as a whole: it captures the mandala logic exactly and omits the welfare-bound, organismic account of internal authority that gives that logic its purpose.

(c) "Principled distance is superior to strict separation." Critically evaluate. [15 marks]

Model answer (285 words; practice model, not official): Position. The claim is correct on one specific test and costly on another, and the evaluation must name both. The two models. Strict separation places institutional distance between state and religion; it guards against establishment and may ignore social inequality among religions. Principled distance makes distance context-sensitive: the state may abstain to protect autonomy and intervene to secure equal citizenship and reform oppressive practice, on reasons drawn from liberty, equality and anti-domination. The test on which principled distance wins. The argument for secularism identifies two failure modes. Religious qualification for citizenship creates unequal citizens - the establishment error. Total immunity of communities from public norms leaves internal domination unchallenged - the abandonment error. Strict separation is calibrated against the first alone, so it cannot address intra-religious domination without ceasing to be strict. The cost. The named risk of principled distance is

that discretion becomes inconsistent or partisan. Unless the model specifies who judges and on what principle, "context-sensitive" is indistinguishable from selective. Objection and reply. Objection: principled distance is unprincipled practice under a respectable name, since any pattern of engagement can be redescribed after the fact. Reply: the model excludes specific things in advance - engagement that establishes or endorses a faith, abstention that leaves members dominated where the state could relieve it, differential treatment unjustified by the three values, and asymmetric application to majority and minority claims. Residual: the exclusions are only as good as the institution applying them, and the model supplies no guaranteed adjudicator. Verdict. Judged by the prevention of intra-religious as well as inter-religious domination, principled distance is superior - at the price of a discretion that must itself be principled, symmetric and reviewable. Superiority is conditional on the safeguard, not established independently of it.

Q3

(a) Assess the claim that misrecognition is an independent dimension of injustice rather than a consequence of material inequality. [20 marks]

Model answer (375 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. The claim is defensible in its analytical form and indefensible in its separatist form: recognition and redistribution are analytically distinct and practically entangled. The two grammars. Maldistribution - exploitation, deprivation, economic marginalisation - is located in the economic structure; its collectivity is a class defined by position in production; used alone it produces economism. Misrecognition - status subordination, stigma, cultural devaluation - is located in institutionalised patterns of cultural value; its collectivity is a status group defined by esteem; used alone it produces culturalism. The argument for independence. Fraser's decisive premise is a pair of cases: a well-paid group can be despised, and a respected group can be poor. Neither wrong is reducible to the other, so a one-dimensional theory will misdiagnose one of them. Her unifying standard is parity of participation - arrangements are just when all adult members can interact as peers - requiring jointly an objective condition of material independence and voice and an intersubjective condition of institutionalised equal respect. The rival position. Honneth holds instead that recognition is the fundamental moral grammar of social conflict, distributive struggles being themselves struggles over what a society esteems. Three spheres - love, rights and solidarity - generate self-confidence, self-respect and self-esteem, injured respectively by abuse, denial of rights and denigration of a way of life. Adjudication. Each has a located weakness. Fraser offers a thinner account of why contempt wounds, since an institutional criterion cannot easily explain an injury felt as damage to the self. Honneth risks psychologising political economy, since automation, capital movement and price changes devastate groups without anyone withholding esteem; his reply that productive contribution is itself a culturally instituted evaluation stretches "recognition" until it explains less. The practical stake. The remedies can pull apart: redistribution often requires dissolving the group as a category, recognition often requires affirming its distinctness, so a programme doing both can appear to affirm an identity it is trying to render irrelevant. Fraser's affirmative/transformational distinction manages this - what is owed is transformation of the value patterns blocking equal standing, including standing inside the group. Indian illustration, bounded. Article 17's abolition of untouchability illustrates a remedy aimed at a status injury; reservations under Articles 15 and 16 combine both. These are dated legal facts and establish nothing about which theory is correct. Verdict.

(b) "Fraternity is the least attended and most necessary of Ambedkar's three principles." Critically discuss. [15 marks]

Model answer (268 words; practice model, not official): Position. The claim is correct about necessity and requires care about what fraternity is. The triad as a structure. Liberty without equality permits domination by the already powerful; equality without liberty suppresses individuality; both without fraternity lack the social disposition to recognise others as equals at all. The three are not parallel goods but mutual conditions. What fraternity names. Not sentimentality or goodwill, but the social basis of democracy - a sense of common associated life among social equals, supported by rights and institutions. It is therefore not the alternative to rights but what rights require in order to function. Why it is most necessary here. Caste is ranked separation: it narrows loyalty to the birth-group and obstructs public spirit, so the disposition to common action among persons who do not know one another is exactly what the order withdraws. A political democracy resting on graded social worth is unstable - one person one vote and one vote one value against unequal worth - and the instability is a deficit of fraternity, not of procedure. The objection. The concept is too vague to do this work: if it cannot be legislated or measured, any failure can be attributed to its absence and any success to its presence. Reply: it is testable where caste operates - whether association across the boundary is free, and whether common action extends beyond the birth-group. The residual limit. Cultivation remains unspecified: no quota produces fraternity, and the owner does not say how it is produced. Verdict. It is most necessary precisely because it is the element no safeguard delivers - which is why safeguards without it remain formal.

(c) Are monarchy and theocracy necessarily related? Discuss with reference to the theory of Divine Right. [15 marks]

Model answer (300 words; practice model, not official): Thesis. Monarchy and theocracy are conceptually distinct forms that the doctrine of Divine Right has historically bridged; they are therefore related contingently, not necessarily. The doctrine. The Divine Right of Kings holds that the monarch rules by God's will and is answerable primarily to God, not to the people. Historically it strengthened absolutism by sacralising political authority: if the king answers to God alone, no earthly forum may call him to account. The two forms, distinguished. In monarchy the ruler is a king, and divine sanction may legitimise his office. In theocracy sovereignty is explicitly vested in God and interpreted through clergy, scripture or sacred law. The compressed formulation is that divine right makes monarchy theologically legitimated, whereas theocracy makes theology politically constitutive. Why the difference is not verbal. The two produce different chains of answerability. Under divine right the chain runs God -> king -> subjects, and the king is the decisive figure. Under theocracy it runs God -> sacred law -> authorised interpreters -> subjects, and the interpreter is decisive, since sacred law does not apply itself. Consequently the characteristic crisis differs: divine-right monarchy breaks at succession and at the king's personal conduct; theocracy breaks at rival interpretation. Objection and reply. Objection: in practice both claim God's authority, both treat dissent as impiety and both escape ordinary accountability, so the distinction is scholastic. Reply: the

convergence is admitted, but the conceptual difference predicts where each regime fails, and a form of government is analysed by its characteristic crisis. The distinction does weaken where the ruler is also chief interpreter, and that should be conceded. Verdict. Not necessarily related: monarchies have rested on heredity, conquest or tradition with no theological claim, and theocratic arrangements have existed without a king. Divine Right is the bridge that explains the historical intersection without establishing a conceptual identity.

Q4

(a) "Neither the village nor centralised modernity is inherently emancipatory for caste." Examine this claim with reference to Gandhi and Ambedkar. [20 marks]

Model answer (333 words; practice model, not official): Position. The claim is correct, and its force lies in replacing a contrast of eras with a test. The two positions. Gandhi treats decentralised community as a possible school of responsibility, meaningful labour and self-rule: it is where conduct is enacted daily, and his constructive programme of education, sanitation and common service presupposes exactly that setting. Ambedkar warns that the actually existing village can concentrate caste authority, dependency and exclusion - precisely because face-to-face dependence makes exit costly and observation constant. Why this is not tradition against modernity. The disagreement is not about eras. Centralised modern institutions can reproduce caste through recruitment, networks and the informal transmission of standing; local community can reproduce it through dependence and surveillance. Neither scale carries emancipation as a property. The test that replaces the contrast. Ask whether scale, technology and community enlarge mobility, equal status, constitutional rights and exit from inherited occupation. That test is applied to both, and it is what makes the claim examinable rather than rhetorical. Running the test. Gandhi's setting scores on shared practice, since common service attacks the ritual rule that certain labour pollutes those who perform it; it scores poorly on exit, because dependence is unchanged and there is nowhere to go. Ambedkar's institutional route scores on rights and exit, since a benefit that can be withdrawn is not a right and representation supplies voice; it scores poorly on everyday relations, which is why he insists that constitutional morality and fraternity must accompany the machinery. Objection and reply. The test is impossible to apply, since mobility and status are not measurable. Reply: it is applied comparatively rather than absolutely - whether an arrangement enlarges or contracts each of the four - and the owner asserts no measurement of any Indian case. Verdict. Neither scale is emancipatory without anti-caste power. The village is not condemned as such and modernity is not credited as such; what decides is whether either arrangement opens the marriage circle, dissolves dependence and secures rights that do not depend on goodwill.

(b) Does technological development lead to progress in the ethical standards of the society? Explain. [15 marks]

Model answer (263 words; practice model, not official): Position. No - not on its own. Technology changes capacities and social relations; it does not supply its own ends. The optimist mechanism, stated fairly. Communication can widen knowledge and sympathy; medicine reduces suffering; productivity can reduce drudgery; transparency tools can aid accountability. Each is a real mechanism, not a straw position. The defeater, and it is structural. Every one of those capacities is double-edged in the same respect. The communication capacity that widens sympathy enables surveillance and manipulation. The medicine that reduces suffering can be distributed unequally, so the capacity exists while the relief does not. The automation that removes drudgery displaces and deskills. The information systems that support accountability reproduce the bias in their inputs. What the symmetry shows. These are one point made four times: the direction of the effect is fixed by who controls the capacity, who can reach it, and what it is aimed at - and none of the three is supplied by the technology. Verdict. Technical progress becomes social progress only when governed by ethical purposes, fair access, accountability and human control. The concession that must be made. The relation is not simply null. Technology reshapes which moral problems arise, creating new occasions for choice, new possible harms and new meaningful duties. What it does not do is supply the criterion by which any of them is settled. Link to progress. This is the non-inevitability argument applied: capacity enlarges for care and destruction alike, institutions distribute its control and risks, and moral learning can be reversed - so progress requires agency, institutions and judgment rather than following from capability.

(c) Critically evaluate Laski's view on sovereignty as a satisfactory position in political theory. [15 marks]

Model answer (283 words; practice model, not official): Naming the test. A position is satisfactory in political theory if it describes political life accurately, protects the values it claims to protect, and supplies an account of the function it displaces. Laski passes the first two tests decisively and the third only partly. The position. Laski rejects the monistic doctrine that the state possesses absolute, indivisible and unlimited sovereignty. Individuals belong simultaneously to family, church, union, guild, cooperative, profession and locality, and these bodies command real loyalty; the state is therefore one association among many, uniquely important but not the sole source of obligation. Allegiance must be earned by protecting rights, securing welfare and enabling meaningful life, not claimed by legal title. Why absolutism is rejected - three grounds of three kinds. Philosophically, no human institution is entitled to unlimited moral obedience; politically, absolute sovereignty legitimises tyranny and suppresses liberty; sociologically, real societies distribute power among many groups. Their independence is the argument's strength: answering one leaves the others standing. First objection and reply. Without a final sovereign, conflict between associations becomes insoluble. Laski replies that legal finality does not eliminate conflict but often suppresses legitimate diversity, and that modern orders need a final procedure, not an unanswerable will. Second objection and reply. Shared sovereignty is conceptually incoherent. His real claim is that the monistic concept itself misdescribes overlapping authority. Residual problem. Neither reply supplies a decision procedure for emergencies, defence or redistribution; MacIver's residual coordinating role concedes exactly this. Verdict. Satisfactory as a critique of absolutism and as a defence of liberty through social plurality; not satisfactory as a complete replacement for the concept of final authority. Note also the phase caution: "Laski abolishes sovereignty" is as inaccurate as "Laski accepts Austin".

SECTION B - Philosophy of Religion

Q5 (COMPULSORY)

(a) State and evaluate the proofs for the existence of God as propounded in Jainism. [10 marks]

Model answer (168 words; practice model, not official): Jainism denies God as creator: the world was never created, since all substances are eternal and change only through modes (utpada-vyaya-dhrauvya). But "Jainism denies God, and yet does not deny godhead. Every liberated soul is a god." Its proofs are accordingly proofs of attainable divinity. First, from the intrinsic nature of the jiva: every soul possesses infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and power (ananta-catustaya), obscured by material karma rather than absent - for we observe degrees of knowledge, not its absence. Second, from gradation to a limiting case: mati, sruta, avadhi and manahpariyaya mark progressive removal of karmic obstruction, whose complete removal is kevala-jnana, omniscience. Third, from the testimony of the omniscient Tirthankaras (apta-vacana), mortals who won liberation by personal effort - "we are all potential Jinas". Evaluation: these establish a plural, achieved, non-creative godhood and rest wholly on Jaina premises - intrinsic omniscience and material karma. They neither prove nor attempt a cosmic God. Sharma's dilemma bites: if karma is inseparable from the soul, liberation is impossible; if separable, bondage is.

(b) "The Euthyphro dilemma refutes divine command theory but leaves theistic ethics standing." Discuss. [10 marks]

Model answer (171 words; practice model, not official): The claim is correct, and stating why requires care about what the dilemma targets. The Euthyphro (10a) asks whether the pious is loved because it is pious or pious because it is loved. On the first horn, command constitutes goodness - so cruelty would have been good had it been commanded, and "God is good" collapses into "God commands what God commands". On the second, the command tracks a goodness it does not create, and the constitutive thesis is abandoned. That is a refutation of a theory of grounding, not of theism. A theist may occupy the second horn deliberately: natural law does exactly this, grounding an objective order of human goods in divine reason while allowing practical reason to know much of it without revelation. Modified divine command theory takes the other route, grounding commands in an essentially loving nature, which blocks arbitrariness at the cost of conceding that "loving" is a moral concept we already grasp. The dilemma therefore removes one theistic ethics and leaves at least two others intact.

(c) Distinguish between rebirth and reincarnation, and explain why the distinction matters for a comparative account of Indian soteriology. [10 marks]

Model answer (151 words; practice model, not official): The distinction. Reincarnation - literally re-enfleshing - presupposes a substantial soul that re-enters a new body. Rebirth is the wider and more neutral term for renewed becoming within a beginningless series, and it commits the user to a continuity-bearer without specifying that the bearer is a substance. Why it matters. (i) It fixes school-attribution: reincarnation is apt for Vedanta, Nyaya and Jainism, and incorrect for Buddhism, whose re-becoming (punarbhava) has no transmigrating self. (ii) It prevents a false consensus: writing "all Indian schools accept reincarnation" silently imports a substance-metaphysics into a school that denies it. (iii) It shapes the modal verdict on necessity questions, since the counter-example only exists once the wider term is available. (iv) Sanskrit registers the range - punarjanma, punaravrtti, punarbhava, samsara - so the distinction is lexical as well as doctrinal. Conclusion. The distinction is not terminological fastidiousness: it is what keeps a comparative account from begging the central metaphysical question.

(d) Can a religious utterance be both performative and truth-apt? Discuss with reference to prayer, confession and doctrinal assertion. [10 marks]

Model answer (136 words; practice model, not official): Religious language performs several acts, but performance does not exhaust cognition. A confession avows commitment, a prayer petitions or praises, and a liturgical formula helps constitute a worshipping practice. Austin's speech-act distinction therefore explains why an utterance may do something rather than merely report a fact. Yet many religious sentences also make truth-claims: 'God is creator' differs from a promise because believers offer reasons, draw implications and reject contradictory assertions. Hare's blik account captures orientation but risks insulating belief from evidence; Wittgensteinian language-games capture use but need not make practices immune to criticism. Aquinas' analogy preserves reference without univocal description, while apophatic theology disciplines overstatement. Thus performative and cognitive functions can coexist. Their relative weight depends on genre: prayer is primarily performative, creed is more assertoric, and myth may disclose meaning without functioning as literal history.

(e) Is Hinduism poly-theistic? Give reasons for your answer. [10 marks]

Model answer (188 words; practice model, not official): Hinduism is polytheistic at the level of ritual plurality: many deities have distinct names, forms, myths and devotional communities, and the Rgvedic pantheon is genuinely function-divided. But the criterion must be announced first - polytheism means plurality of ultimates, not of names, forms or access-points. Three texts block the simple label. Rgveda 1.164.46 says the one existent is spoken of variously by the wise, naming Indra, Mitra, Varuna and Agni as designations of a single referent. Rgveda 10.129 (Nasadiya) resolves origins into "the One" and then doubts whether even the highest overseer knows. Brhadaranyaka 3.9 reduces "three and three thousand" gods to one. Vedic religion is therefore better called henotheistic or kathenotheistic - F. Max Muller's terms for the pattern in which the invoked deity is addressed as supreme without the others being denied. Devotional and philosophical structures reinforce this. The chosen deity (istadevata), descent-forms (avatara) and the Vaisnava, Saiva and Sakta theisms are each monotheistic in form. Advaita makes deities empirically valid but non-dual Brahman ultimate; Ramanuja affirms one personal Brahman qualified by real selves and world; Nyaya posits one omniscient Isvara as cosmic governor.

Q6

(a) Compare St. Thomas Aquinas' five ways of knowing God with the arguments of the Nyaya School of Indian Philosophy for the existence of God. [20 marks]

Model answer (362 words; practice model, not official): Aquinas and the Naiyayikas both practise a posteriori natural theology: each begins from a general feature of the world and argues to an ultimate intelligent reality. Their convergence is real, and so is their divergence. Aquinas' Five Ways (Summa Theologiae I, q.2, a.3) argue from change to a prime mover; from efficient causation to a first cause; from contingency to a necessary being; from degrees of perfection to a maximum; and from purposive regularity in non-cognitive nature to a divine intelligence. The regress he excludes is essentially ordered - the stick moves the stone only while the hand moves the stick - so "first" means explanatory priority, not the earliest event in time. Nyaya's Isvara-anumana proceeds through several routes. Karyat: composite objects are effects, since they are made of parts (savayava) and possess intermediate magnitude (avantara-mahattva); material causes cannot achieve the required order and co-ordination without an intelligent maker, who must be omniscient, since only such a being can directly know atoms. Ayojanat: inert atoms need purposive combination. Dhrtiyadeh: the world's support and dissolution require governance. Padat / sruteh: Vedic authority presupposes an omniscient author. Finally, the argument from adrsta: the unconscious stock of merit and demerit cannot allot determinate joys and sorrows, so God is karmaphaladata. The convergence: both infer intelligence from order; both add attributes stepwise rather than by definition; both are cumulative rather than single-inference systems, Udayana multiplying routes exactly as Aquinas multiplies Ways. The divergence is decisive. Aquinas' God is the cause of being, creating ex nihilo; Nyaya's Isvara is the efficient cause only, ordering eternal, uncreated atoms while souls, space, time and adrsta remain co-present with Him. Aquinas' proofs are praeambula fidei drawn from reason alone; two Nyaya arguments are explicitly scriptural. Aquinas' God is unconditioned; Nyaya's is morally constrained by adrsta. Consequently the critiques differ in weight. Hume's analogy objection strikes Nyaya hardest, since its inference is expressly artefact-modelled on pot and potter; while the redundancy objection - that karma and atoms could operate without a supervisor - is uniquely Indian and, as C. D. Sharma presses it, uniquely damaging. Verdict: the same inferential architecture, but not the same God: Aquinas' terminus is metaphysically ultimate, Nyaya's is cosmically administrative.

(b) Critically evaluate the Buddhistic arguments against the existence of God as the creator of the world. [15 marks]

Model answer (261 words; practice model, not official): Buddhism rejects a creator God (jagat-karta) without rejecting spiritual ultimacy; its critique is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus rather than bare atheism. Four canonical lines recur. First, if God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation is hard to explain, since willing or producing appears to involve change; Dharmakirti-type reasoning sharpens this - a permanent, immutable cause fully present at all times should produce its effect always and at once, never in temporal succession. Second, if God creates from desire or purpose, this implies lack, preference or incompleteness, which is inconsistent with perfection. Third, suffering and evil sit uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator. Fourth, dependent origination already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, so a creator is redundant. To these may be added the methodological point that questions of a first beginning fall among the avyakta, undeclared because soteriologically idle - the wounded man who insists on knowing the archer before the arrow is removed. Evaluation must be even-handed. The change objection assumes a temporal model of divine willing; classical theism answers with a single eternal act producing a temporal effect. The desire objection assumes creation must remedy a lack; theists appeal to gratuitous diffusive goodness. Most importantly, Nyaya replies that dependent origination explains sequence but not desert-appropriate allocation: an unconscious nexus cannot proportion determinate fruit to determinate merit. Explanatory economy, moreover, is a methodological preference, not a disproof. Verdict: Buddhism establishes that a coherent, ethically serious cosmology is possible without a creator. That is a substantial philosophical achievement - but it shifts the burden of proof rather than closing the question.

(c) Can a non-theistic religion retain worship, transcendence and liberation without covertly reintroducing God? Discuss. [15 marks]

Model answer (211 words; practice model, not official): Religion need not be defined by belief in a creator. Buddhism and Jainism organise doctrine, discipline, community and liberation without a sovereign God. Their objects of reverence are awakened teachers, perfected beings, truth and a path of transformation rather than a creator who commands obedience. Worship can therefore express gratitude, emulation and moral self-formation. Transcendence also need not mean a supernatural person: nirvana transcends craving and conditioned suffering, while Jain liberation releases the soul from karmic bondage. The objection is that ultimate law, the Buddha ideal or liberated beings may perform functions commonly assigned to God. Yet functional similarity is not identity. Neither dependent origination nor karma is an omniscient will, and liberation is not divine grace. Non-theistic traditions thus show that religion can centre on diagnosis, practice and transformation. They do not covertly restore God unless every object of ultimacy is defined as divine, a definition so broad that it erases the distinction under examination. The institutional test is equally important: monastic rules, confession, pilgrimage and ethical vows can sustain a religious form of life without prayer to a creator. The concept of religion should therefore be family-resemblance based, not tied to one Abrahamic model of belief. This preserves genuine doctrinal difference instead of translating every path into disguised theism.

Q7

(a) "Religion supplies morality with motivation and scope; morality supplies religion with a standard. Neither supplies the other with a foundation." Critically evaluate. [20 marks]

Model answer (393 words; practice model, not official): The thesis is defensible in all three of its parts, and evaluating it requires separating grounding from everything else. Neither supplies a foundation - the first half. Morality is not conceptually grounded in religion. The Euthyphro forces the choice between arbitrariness, on which "God is good" is a tautology, and independence, on which goodness is prior to command. Modified divine command theory blocks the first horn by grounding commands in an essentially loving

nature, and Alston denies the regress by treating God as the supreme standard; but describing that nature as loving uses a moral concept we must already possess, so non-arbitrariness is bought with conceptual independence. Four independent non-theistic groundings confirm the result empirically: Kantian self-legislation; Mimamsa's duty from injunction alone, which retains scriptural authority while removing any personal commander; Santideva's derivation of impartial altruism from the ownerlessness of suffering; and the Jain vow-structure around non-injury. Neither supplies a foundation - the second half. Religion is not grounded in morality either. A religion is more than an ethic: it makes claims about ultimate reality, transformation and liberation, and reducing it to morality misdescribes it as thoroughly as reducing morality to command misdescribes morality. Religion supplies motivation and scope. The mechanisms are identifiable - exemplars, ritual formation, community sanction, hope and repentance, a sustaining worldview - and the scope claim is strongest in the hard case. Where secular theories stop at the undetected, costly act, karma is exhaustive and impersonal, so invisibility to persons is irrelevant, and *niskama-karma* (2.47, 3.19) removes the fruit from deliberation entirely. Morality supplies a standard. Conscience criticises religious practice, and does so most powerfully from within: prophetic denunciation of ritual without justice, and reform against caste and sati. A claimed command remains answerable to identification, interpretation, consistency, proportionality, human dignity and the standing of the authority invoked. The qualifications that decide the grade. The motivational advantage is priced: if it operates through sanction it is heteronomous and forfeits moral worth, so only the divine-love and *niskama-karma* versions win it cleanly. The influence is contingent: the same mechanisms can sanction exclusion. And the asymmetry the thesis implies needs its own explanation - morality is constitutive of what qualifies as a religion, while religion is only supportive of morality. Verdict, and the defeater. The thesis is correct: the relation is one of motivation, scope and mutual criticism, not of foundation in either direction.

(b) Critically examine the idea of Brahman in Advaita philosophy of Samkara. Does Samkara's conception of Brahman leave room for theism? Discuss. [15 marks]

Model answer (286 words; practice model, not official): Samkara's Advaita identifies *nirguna* Brahman as the sole ultimate (*paramarthika*) reality: non-dual, self-revealing consciousness beyond limiting, relational predicates. *Sat-cit-ananda* does not add three properties to Brahman; these are its essential nature-defining marks (*svarupa-laksana*), as against the relational definition of Brahman as world-cause (*tatastha-laksana*, "that from which arises the origin of this"). *Neti neti* (*Brhadaranyaka* 2.3.6) removes objectifying descriptions rather than reducing Brahman to nothing, and *Taittiriya* 2.9 marks the failure of speech, not the absence of reality. The experienced plurality of self, world and deity is explained through *maya* and superimposition (*adhyasa*). The world is dependent and sublatale, not sheer non-being; it is the world-appearance, not Brahman, that is properly called indeterminable (*anirvacaniya*). Brahman does not really transform: the world is apparent transformation (*vivarta*), as a snake appears on a rope. Viewed in relation to *maya*, Brahman is *saguna Isvara*, omniscient creator, moral governor and object of worship at the transactional (*vyavaharika*) level. This clearly leaves room for theism. Devotion, meditation, scripture and divine governance possess genuine empirical validity and purify the mind for liberating knowledge. Yet the room is provisional, because knowledge finally sublates the distinction among worshipper, worshipped and world; ultimate Brahman is neither a person alongside persons nor a creator in an unsublatable relation. Ramanuja objects that a quality-less absolute is unintelligible and demotes religion, since what is wholly undetermined is neither knowable, nameable nor worshippingable. Advaita replies that finite predicates limit ultimacy and that negation removes superimposition, not reality. The reply preserves absoluteness but leaves positive intelligibility and the final status of devotion under pressure. Therefore Samkara is neither a straightforward theist nor an atheist: Advaita validates empirical theism as path while transcending it in non-dual realisation as goal.

(c) Assess the claim that moral criticism of religious practice is necessarily an external, secular imposition. [15 marks]

Model answer (282 words; practice model, not official): The claim is false, and the evidence that refutes it comes from inside the traditions. Moral criticism of religion is standardly internal. The Hebrew prophets denounce festivals and sacrifices offered without justice; the Buddha criticises Vedic sacrifice as ineffective; Kabir and Nanak attack ritualism and caste-observance; the Gita (2.42-43) disparages those enchanted by promises of ritual reward. Reform movements against caste and sati argued in religious vocabulary, appealing to non-harm, equality, conscience and spiritual unity. The structural point is more important than the examples. Interpretation of a claimed command already deploys moral concepts: identifying which reading is faithful, which authority is legitimate, and which application is proportionate cannot be done without them. The six tests to which any claimed command remains answerable - identification, interpretation, consistency, proportionality, human dignity and the moral status of the authority invoked - are therefore not imported after the fact. They are already operating inside the interpretive act. This answers the standing objection that morality judging revelation is arrogance, the finite judging the infinite. What is being judged is a human claim about a command, not the divine as such. Two qualifications are owed. First, religious moralities conflict with one another over duties, authority, exceptions and interpretation, so internal criticism does not converge on a single moral code. Second, the reply that an immoral religious practice is internal corruption rather than a counter-example works only if morality is genuinely treated as constitutive of worthy religion - which is a substantive commitment, not a rhetorical escape. Moral criticism of religion is therefore neither necessarily secular nor necessarily hostile. It is most powerful precisely where it is internal, because there it cannot be met by the charge of imposing alien standards.

Q8

(a) Critically compare the Semitic doctrine of resurrection with the Indian doctrine of rebirth, and assess whether either succeeds in securing the identity of the person who survives. [20 marks]

Model answer (331 words; practice model, not official): Frame. These are not variants of one idea. They differ in number of lives, mechanism, judge, telos, identity-bearer, treatment of the body and direction of time. Cullmann (1955) argues that Greek immortality of the soul and Hebrew resurrection of the dead are opposed rather than complementary - the first releases the soul from the body,

the second treats the person as a psychosomatic unity that only a divine act can restore. The grid. Resurrection: one earthly life; a divine act at the end of history; God as judge; restored embodied life in communion; the body essential, a "spiritual body" still a body; linear time. Rebirth: a beginningless series; karma maturing through the wandering-on; the karmic law itself, with God ratifying in Nyaya and Ramanuja; exit from the series as telos; the body discarded like clothing (Gita 2.22) while the subtle body carries dispositions; cyclical time with a linear exit. Identity under resurrection. Two problems: the gap between death and raising, and the re-assembly objection where matter is shared between bodies. Three replies: Aquinas (the rational soul as form secures continuity); van Inwagen (God preserves the body or a core, leaving a simulacrum); Hick (a unique psychophysical replica with memory and character is the person). The duplication objection is decisive against the third as stated: if one replica, why not two? Identity under rebirth. The memory objection: nothing of prior lives is recalled. The reply distinguishes episodic memory from metaphysical continuity and appeals to latent dispositions - coherent, but evidentially empty. Buddhism avoids the problem by abandoning strict identity for causal descent, at the cost of the ownership worry. Assessment. Neither secures identity, but for opposite reasons: resurrection must show that a re-constituted person is numerically the same; rebirth must show that a being with no memory of me is me. Conclusion. They answer different questions - how an essentially embodied person can survive, and how moral desert can be discharged when one life is too short - and both leave the identity question open.

(b) The problem of evil is a direct offshoot of how God is conceptualised in a system." Critically discuss. [15 marks]

Model answer (257 words; practice model, not official): The thesis is correct, and its demonstration is straightforward. State the classical set: God is omnipotent, omniscient, perfectly good and creator, and evil exists; the contradiction requires the bridging principles that a good being eliminates evil as far as it can and that omnipotence has no relevant limit. The argument bites only where all four attributes are held together. Now vary the concept. Weaken omnipotence and the process God, whose power is persuasive by metaphysical necessity, is simply not the kind of being who could have prevented the evil unilaterally - the charge lapses. Weaken personality and Advaita's nirguna Brahman is untouched: evil is real at the empirical level (vyavaharika) and sublated under liberating knowledge at the ultimate level (paramarthika). Remove the creator and Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa have no defendant at all: suffering is explained by conditions and by deeds, and the moral law is self-operating. Only classical theism carries the full burden. The critical half is the price list. The process route surrenders sovereignty and any guarantee of final victory over evil. Advaita risks minimising present suffering. Non-creator systems give up providence, divine rescue and a personal guarantor of justice. Concept-dependence is therefore not a solution: it moves the cost from the argument into the theology. The theodicies - free-will, soul-making, privation - exist precisely because some theists refuse to pay that price and try to keep every attribute. Verdict: the problem is a stress-test of a particular God-concept, not of religion as such - which is why the same suffering that refutes one theology leaves another entirely untouched.

(c) What is the logical problem of evil? Discuss. [15 marks]

Model answer (267 words; practice model, not official): The logical problem alleges that a set of theistic beliefs cannot all be true. J. L. Mackie, "Evil and Omnipotence" (Mind, 1955), sets out the propositions: God is omnipotent; God is perfectly good; and evil exists. The full classical profile adds omniscience, which blocks the reply that evil escaped divine notice. Crucially, these propositions are not formally contradictory by themselves. Nothing in them, plus logic alone, entails both a proposition and its negation. The contradiction is manufactured by two bridging principles: first, that a perfectly good being eliminates evil as far as it can; second, that an omnipotent being has no relevant limit on preventing any evil whose prevention is logically possible. Mackie sorts the replies into adequate solutions, which honestly abandon one proposition, and fallacious solutions, which appear to keep all three while covertly limiting power or redefining goodness. The theist has three exits, each attacking a bridge. Insert "unless there is a morally sufficient reason" into the goodness bridge, and the whole space of defences and theodicies opens. Deny the power bridge and one gets Plantinga's free-will defence: significant freedom entails genuine alternatives, God cannot causally determine a creature to freely choose only rightly, so a world containing moral good may be unavailable without moral evil. Plantinga needs only possibility, which is why transworld depravity is asserted as possible and never as actual. Denying the reality of evil - privation, or the empirical level in Advaita - is the third and most costly exit. Verdict: the logical problem is widely regarded as answered; the live debate has migrated to Rowe's evidential form, where consistency no longer suffices.

END OF DETAILED SOLUTIONS